

Universal grammar



One of the questions that occupied linguistics was whether there is a common grammatical structure to all human languages. There are families of related languages that share similar grammars but the many different families seem to have little or nothing in common. An answer to this problem came from Noam Chomsky, later better known for his critical analysis of political power (see [Analysis of political power](#)). He noticed that children become proficient in their mother tongue far more quickly than one might expect from the amount of stimulus they are given, and regardless of the particular language a child is learning. Chomsky concluded that we

must have some innate knowledge of the structure of language, and that this structure must be common to all languages – a universal or ‘generative’ grammar. The notion of language having a universal formal structure was analogous to the link between logic and mathematics, but the idea of an *a priori* understanding of it harked back to Cartesian rationalism and was difficult to square with linguistics’ claim to be a scientific discipline in the empiricist tradition.